

Silence and Implication Lab Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 20-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	silence-and-implication-lab

Big idea: Meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Dialogue: 'Did you like my presentation?' 'Well, your slides were very colorful.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Silence and Implication Lab Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Meaning often depends on implication; silence can communicate without explicitly claiming.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Silence and Implication Lab Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can silence be evidence?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Dialogue: 'Did you like my presentation?' 'Well, your slides were very colorful.'
- Dialogue: 'Are you coming to the meeting?' 'I have a lot of homework tonight.'

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Activity Steps

- 1. Give pairs a short dialogue with one ambiguous silence or indirect reply.
- 2. Students list what was explicitly said and what was implied.
- 3. Groups add context cards that change the implication.
- 4. Students decide which interpretation is most justified.
- 5. Debrief how implication functions in everyday and institutional knowledge.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can silence be evidence?
- How do context and shared norms make implication possible?
- When is reading between the lines responsible and when is it overinterpretation?

Knowledge Questions

- Can silence be evidence?
- How do shared norms shape meaning?
- What makes an implied claim justified?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with statements where what is unsaid changes the implied meaning. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...